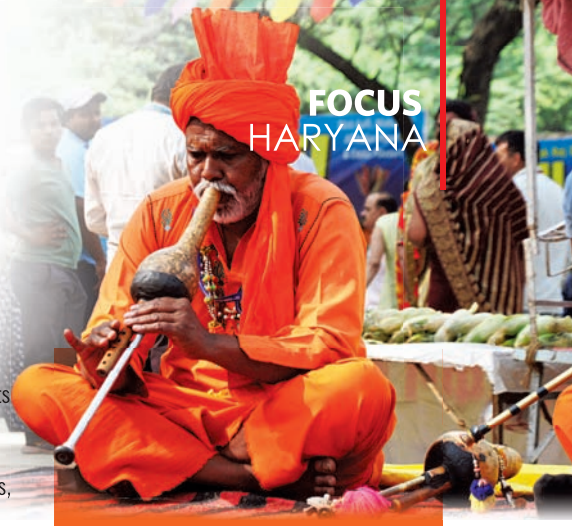


we were able to hold it very successfully. In spite of COVID restrictions and rise of temperature, people turned up in large numbers and made the mela a grand success."

A CELEBRATION OF LIFE IN ITS MYRIAD COLOURS

The mela ground is spread over 40 acres and houses over a thousand work huts to host craftspersons and weavers. This gives it the ambience of a sprawling crafts village. This year the mela was a riot of colours and energy. Throughout the fairgrounds, visitors were met with vibrant cultural performances. The atmosphere was livened up with street performers, from drummers and musicians to baharupiyas and bioscope-walas. The mela visitors danced like there was no tomorrow.

The Main Chaupal was the primary venue and was reserved for the most spectacular cultural performances, especially in the evenings.

Uzbekistan as the Partner Nation had pride of place at the festival, showcasing its famed pottery, souvenirs and textiles. The international showcase this year included arts, crafts and textiles from countries as diverse as Ghana, Tunisia, Sri Lanka, Thailand and so on. The Sri Lanka stall had some gorgeous handmade lace for sale. Tunisia had intricate and colourful pottery among its wares. The visitors were enthusiastically making purchases.

On the Indian front, apart from beautiful textiles and garments from across the country, there were also purveyors of organic honey, exotic spices, genuine Hyderabadi pearls and fine pottery. Jamu & Kashmir showcased its famed textiles and souvenirs as well as recreations of the Khanqah-e-Moula shrine and a typical Kashmiri house.

SEAMLESS ARRANGEMENT

Today the mela is organised by Haryana Tourism and Surajkund Mela Authority in collaboration with the Union Ministries of Tourism, Textiles, Culture and External Affairs. Several new initiatives were taken by Haryana Tourism this year to make the mela a breeze for visitors. A first for any mela anywhere in India was the implementation of an online parking system. Basically, visitors could book their parking slots online. The mela tickets could also be purchased online.

On the important sanitation front, Chadha says, "We created a lot of toilets throughout the venue. This year we worked very hard to make the mela litter and garbage free at any point of time. At night also after a whole day's mela you could not find any garbage anywhere. We also introduced some taps for drinking water."

Besides this, apps to guide visitors to the type of stall or craftsperson they wanted to visit were also available in the mela.

Chadha is appreciative of the coverage the mela has received this year. "I want to thank media partners because this year they have very proactively covered the mela in spite of COVID. It was a bit different from 2020, because after that many things have changed our lives. In spite of COVID and the heat, media people visited and covered this mela. They have also positively highlighted the cultural and national integration aspects of this mela."

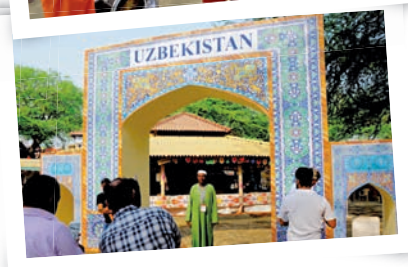
Many art installations, gates and sculptures have been added to the mela over the years and they continue to delight visitors in subsequent years and offer great photo-ops. This year, more than 300 artists gave cultural performances over the course of two weeks and the mela saw about 8.5-9 lakh visitors.

The Surajkund International Crafts Mela offers visitors a lifetime experience as it unfolds a wonderful range of textiles, paintings, pottery, and handicrafts products. To the rhythm of drum beats and with a splash of colours, the mela comes alive year after year.









MELA HIGHLIGHTS

The highlight of the mela was a Latin American conclave that was organised on the side-lines of the main activities. "Around 11 delegations from Latin American countries came and appreciated our culture and unique handicrafts," says Chadha, "During the conclave, we organised B2B meetings for the delegations. The mela was a great platform for creating investment and social ties with these Latin American countries."

As far as the cultural highlights of the mela are concerned, Chadha elaborates, "We had diverse cultural themes, starting from North India, with Jammu & Kashmir being our Partner State, and then the Southern states, covering every bit of India's geography. On the night of the Latin American Conclave, the 11 countries from Latin America who were attending also participated in the cultural performances and activities. One night was totally devoted to them."

A plethora of cultural events—on a never-before-seen-scale—made the mela an experience to remember. From traditional Indian dance forms like Bhangra to African dances, there was something for everyone. The venues consisted of village-style Chaupals and open-air amphitheatres.

The multi-cuisine Food Court was another highlight of the mela. There were designated places for amusement, adventure sports and joy rides too, ensuring that the mela appealed to kids.